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Data Science Capstone - Topic
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Topic

How U.S. College Professor Salaries Compare to Regional Cost of Living

Description

This project investigates whether college professor salaries reflect true purchasing power once regional cost-of-living differences are taken into account, comparing nominal and cost-adjusted salaries across U.S. institutions and geographic regions.

Data Aspect

Faculty salary data by institution, rank, and discipline (e.g., from IPEDS or the AAUP Faculty Compensation Survey) merged with regional cost-of-living indices at the metro or state level (e.g., BEA Regional Price Parities or the C2ER Cost of Living Index), along with institutional characteristics such as public/private status and Carnegie classification.

Advanced Data-Analytic Method

I plan to use a multiple regression model to test how much of the variation in professor salaries is explained by regional cost of living, alongside descriptive comparisons (e.g., rankings or maps) of "adjusted" salaries across institutions and regions.